How to run a debate

Post-16 and college: Sixth form and college. Two schools, one motion, 30 minutes. Everything you need to run the debate, from setting up the room to the final vote.

DEBATE TIME	AGE GROUP	CLASS SIZE	WHERE	JUDGED ON
30 minutes	**Post-16 and college**	**About 30**	**In person or online**	**Argument, Evidence, Rebuttal, Delivery**

Two to three weeks before

1. **Agree the fixture.** On the debate page: the date, in person or online, the theme, the motion and a judge. Tell your students which side your school argues.
2. **Survey your own students.** Students write their own questions, starting from the ones below, and note the limits of their survey: sample size and leading wording. Use the same questions as the other school, from your prep pack, so the results can be compared on the day. Do not record names.
3. **Research in three groups.** Independent research, with a note of how reliable each source is.
   - **The facts:** What is actually true, and how do we know?
   - **The people affected:** Who gains, who loses, and who is not in the room?
   - **Rules and responsibilities:** Who decides, who is accountable, and what should the rules be?
4. **Check every fact twice.** Use more than one source for each fact, and write down where it came from. Never rely on AI-generated content alone: it can be wrong and still sound certain.
5. **Name your roles** (see Who does what).
6. **Prepare the speeches.** Start with a 60-second brainstorm of everything that comes to mind, then pick one central idea that every point leads back to. List the arguments you expect from the other side. Plan each speech as an opening line that hooks the room, two or three points with evidence, and a strong last line.

7. **Notes.** Headings only: the opening line, a heading and the key evidence for each argument, and a separate rebuttal sheet with space left to write what the other side says. Speakers should not read a script.
8. **Warm up in lessons.** Short games, one for each part of speaking well:
    - **Say it with feeling** (voice): say an ordinary sentence as if angry, excited or worried, and the group guesses the feeling.
    - **Don’t say the word** (words): describe a word on a card, such as “privacy”, without saying it.
    - **Because, but, so** (reasons): round the circle, each person adds to a claim with “because”, “but” or “so”.
    - **Say it back** (listening): before giving a view, sum up what the last speaker said, until they agree you have it right.
9. **Rehearse in debate conditions:** standing up, against the timer, with someone asking questions or interrupting.
10. **Practise.** Practise points of information: how to offer one, and how a speaker accepts or declines it. Have students note how reliable each source is.

What you need

For every debate

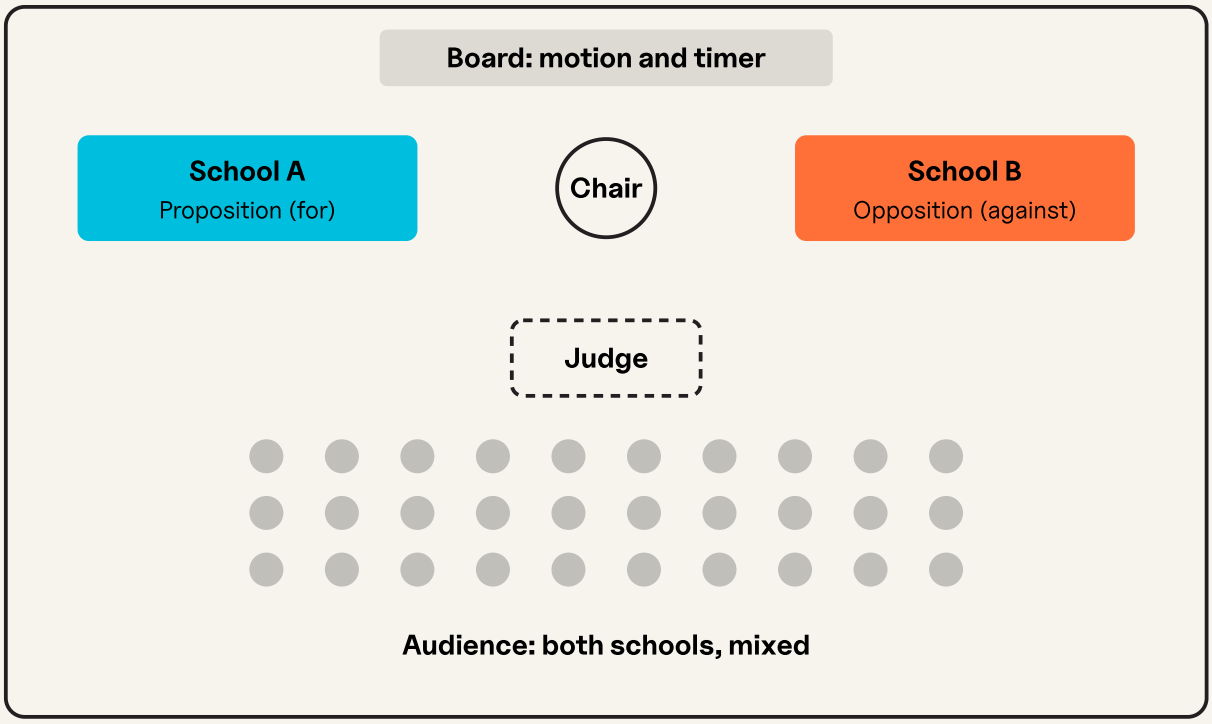
- [ ] The motion on the board, where everyone can read it
- [ ] A timer everyone can see, on the board or a large screen
- [ ] Timing cards for the chair: 30 seconds and Stop, held up with each knock (see On the day)
- [ ] A rebuttal card for each team, printed from this guide
- [ ] Two tables at the front, facing the audience, with chairs for each team
- [ ] Each school's survey chart: one slide or one printed sheet
- [ ] Note-taking sheets and pens for the note-takers and the audience
- [ ] The judge's scorecard: on their phone, or printed from the debate page in case the Wi-Fi fails

For post-16 and college

- [ ] Research notes, with a note of how reliable each source is
- [ ] A phone or tablet poll for the vote, if you are not using a show of hands

Online? You also need a camera, a room microphone and a projector: see If you debate online.

Set up the room



The room from above. School A, the Proposition, argues for; School B, the Opposition, argues against.

1. **Front of the room:** School A's table on one side and School B's on the other, both facing the audience. Speakers stand to speak.
2. **The chair** sits between the two tables, with the timer on the board behind them.
3. **The judge** sits facing the front, where they can see and hear both teams, slightly apart from the audience.
4. **The audience** sits in rows or a horseshoe, mixed between the schools, with a clear path for questioners to stand.
5. **Check before anyone arrives:** the motion and the timer are on the board, and the survey charts are ready to show.

Who does what

For a class of about 30. Each school names six roles. Everyone else is a note-taker or a questioner, so the whole room has a job.

ROLE	WHAT THEY DO
Chair (1, agreed between the schools)	Introduces the motion and the rules, keeps time, takes the floor questions and announces the votes. Often a teacher at primary; a student can chair at secondary and post-16.
Judge (1)	Invited by the host school. Scores each school from 1 to 5 on argument, evidence, rebuttal, delivery, and submits the official result.
Survey presenters (2)	Share the school's survey findings at the start.
Opening speaker (1)	Makes the school's case.
Rebuttal speaker (1)	Answers what the other side said, using the notes.
Closing speaker (1)	Sums up in the school's last minute.
Lead note-taker (1)	Listens to the other side and briefs the rebuttal speaker.
Note-takers	Listen to the other side's opening case, and feed the rebuttal in the huddle.
Questioners	Ask the floor questions to either side.

> **Teacher tip.** Speakers may offer and take points of information during the opening cases. The lead note-taker tracks which points went unanswered, for the rebuttal.

Keeping order. The chair keeps order by saying “Order!”: for noise during a speech, interrupting, a speaker running on well past time, or anything discourteous. The judge says nothing during the debate: they listen, take notes and score.

On the day, step by step

The first 10 minutes set the scene; the rest is the debate. The time beside each step is minutes from the start. Where a stage says “each”, each school has that long in turn.

Timing signals

One knock after 30 seconds	Points of information may now be offered.
One knock 30 seconds before the end	Last 30 seconds: no more points of information. Hold up the 30 seconds card.
Two knocks	Time is up: finish the sentence. Hold up Stop.
Knocking that keeps going	From 15 seconds over, until the speaker sits down.

The first and last 30 seconds of each opening case are protected: no points of information. A point of information lasts about 10 seconds, and the speaker may accept or decline it. Offering too many, so the speaker cannot get going, is unfair, but a team that never offers or accepts one is not listening.

1 0:00

Welcome and roles 2 min

The chair introduces the motion and the rules, and confirms who is speaking, taking notes and asking questions.

Students: Speakers sit at their school's table; everyone else sits in the audience.

> **Teacher tip.** Explain points of information: stand and say “Point of information”; the speaker accepts or declines. None in the first or last 30 seconds of a speech.

2 2:00

Opening vote 2 min

The room votes for, against or undecided, and the result is recorded.

Students: Everyone votes for, against or undecided.

> **Teacher tip.** Write the numbers on the board and leave them there: you need them for the swing at the end.

3 4:00

Survey findings 3 min each

Each school shares what its own students said: a simple chart and one key finding.

Students: The two survey presenters from each school share their chart and one key finding.

> **Teacher tip.** Ask presenters to name one limit of their survey: sample size or leading wording.

4 10:00

Opening cases 3½ min each

Proposition, then Opposition. The other side takes notes and may offer points of information in the middle of each speech.

Students: The opening speaker makes the case, and may accept points of information from the other side.

> **Teacher tip.** One knock and the 30 seconds card when time is nearly up; two knocks and Stop at the end. Let them finish the sentence.

5 17:00

Rebuttal preparation 2 min

Each team huddles with its note-takers, while the audience talks in pairs.

Students: The note-takers tell the rebuttal speaker which points to answer. In the audience, pairs talk about the strongest point so far.

> **Teacher tip.** The lead note-taker briefs the rebuttal speaker. Keep the timer running on the board.

6 19:00

Rebuttal 2 min each

Opposition goes first, then Proposition.

Students: The rebuttal speaker answers what the other side actually said, using the notes.

> **Teacher tip.** A rebuttal is not a second speech. Listen for “They said… but…”.

7 23:00

Floor questions 3 min

The chair takes questions from the audience, to either side.

Students: Take three or four questions in a row, from both schools. Teams do not answer straight away: they answer in their closing speeches. Nobody questions their own school's team.

> **Teacher tip.** Note each question on the board, so the closing speakers can see what they need to answer.

8 26:00

Closing 1½ min each

Opposition first, Proposition last.

Students: The closing speaker answers the floor questions and sums up the two or three biggest disagreements.

> **Teacher tip.** Nothing new, except to develop what was already said: in competitions, a brand-new argument in a closing speech loses marks.

9 29:00

Final vote and result 1 min

A show of hands or a digital vote. The chair announces the swing: who changed their minds.

Students: Everyone votes again, the same way as at the start, so the two votes can be compared.

> **Teacher tip.** The vote shows who persuaded the room; the judge's scorecard is the official result.

Rebuttal card

Rebuttal answers what the other side actually said. Take on their strongest argument, even if your answer is not perfect: ignoring it is worse.

REBUTTAL CARD: POST-16 AND COLLEGE

Factually wrong
The claim is false, out of date or unsourced.

Wrong cause
It mistakes what causes what, or reads the evidence the wrong way round.

Doesn't follow
The conclusion does not follow from the reasons.

Morally flawed
It is true, but the cost to people outweighs the benefit.

Unimportant or irrelevant
True, but too small to decide the debate, or beside the point.

Contradiction
Two speakers on the same side disagree, or a promised argument never arrived.

Counter-rebuttal
When they answer your point, show why their answer fails, so your point still stands.

What a good speech sounds like

Four skill sets, as used by the English-Speaking Union to judge the Schools' Mace. Use them as success criteria while students prepare, and for feedback afterwards. The right-hand column shows where each one counts on our judge's scorecard.

SKILL SET	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE	OUR SCORECARD
Expression and delivery	Varies pitch, pace and pauses; eye contact and open body language; clear words; brief notes, not a script read aloud.	Delivery
Reasoning and evidence	A clear position from the start; each point backed by an example or fact, and why it matters; takes on the other side's view.	Argument, Evidence
Organisation and prioritisation	Signposts its points; a strong opening and ending; adapts when the debate changes; keeps to time.	Argument, Delivery
Listening and response	Answers questions directly, not by repeating the speech; responds to what was said; stays calm when challenged.	Rebuttal

Persuasive techniques worth teaching: the rule of three, repetition of a key phrase, a rhetorical question, a metaphor that makes an idea easy to picture. A short story only helps if it links straight back to the argument.

How debating grows, Key Stage 2 to 5

Each stage builds on the one before. Your students' stage is highlighted; move a confident group on to the next column.

	KS2	KS3	KS4	KS5
Notes	Read from a card	Prompt cards	Headings only	Headings only, no script
Rebuttal	"I disagree because…"	Not true, doesn't follow, doesn't matter	Adds contradictions	The full list, and counter-rebuttal
Interruptions	None	None	Points of information, optional	Points of information, with protected time
Floor questions	Written on sticky notes first	Asked live, answered straight away	Asked live, or answered in closing	Answered in the closing speeches
Feedback	Four "ask yourself" questions	ESU four skill sets	ESU four skill sets	ESU four skill sets

Keeping it fair

- ☐ Sides are given, not chosen. Tell students it is fine to argue a side they disagree with: that is the skill.
- ☐ Both sides get the same time and the same chance to answer.
- ☐ The chair and teachers stay neutral, and keep their own views on the motion to themselves.
- ☐ Some AI motions touch on political questions, such as who should make the rules. The debate format gives students at least two genuinely different views, which is what the DfE asks for.
- ☐ The judge is a visitor: follow your school's usual visitor and safeguarding checks, and a teacher stays in the room.
- ☐ Challenge the argument, never the person. Personal remarks are stopped by the chair.

See the DfE's Political impartiality in schools (updated March 2025), in Further reading.

Including every student

- [ ] Every role counts. Note-takers, questioners and survey presenters shape the debate as much as the speakers.
- [ ] Speakers may read from a card, share a speech between two, or use sign language or a communication aid. Oracy includes all of these.
- [ ] If a student stammers, give them time and never finish their sentences. Brief the judge: a stammer is never marked down under Delivery.
- [ ] Use the cards and the knocks together, so every student can see or hear the time.
- [ ] Give the motion and the questions early to anyone who needs more time to think, and keep sentence starters on display.
- [ ] Give students learning English a short list of key words for the motion, and let them prepare with a partner.
- [ ] Plan adjustments with your SENCO, as you would for any lesson.

After the debate

1. **The judge submits the scorecard** on their phone, or enters the paper one later. Their submission is the official result, and both schools see it on the debate page.
2. **Ask your students again.** Run the survey after the debate with a class PIN, to see whether views changed.
3. **Talk about it.** What was the strongest argument on the other side? Did anything change your mind?
4. **Be recognised.** Taking part is recorded straight away. Two debates against two different schools earns the National AI Debate School certificate.

If you debate online

The host school, School A, sets up the meeting on its own platform and adds the link to the debate page. The link is then on the debate page and in both calendar entries.

Equipment

- [ ] One computer in each room, with a camera that shows the speakers
- [ ] A room microphone or speakerphone, so the whole team can be heard
- [ ] A projector and speakers, so the room sees and hears the other school
- [ ] The timer shared on screen by the chair, so both rooms see it

Running it

- [ ] Test the link, sound and camera together 15 minutes before
- [ ] The host admits everyone from the waiting room and controls who joins
- [ ] Nobody records the debate, and the chat stays off
- [ ] Speakers come to the camera to speak; mute the room when it is not your turn
- [ ] Votes: hands up to the camera, counted in each room, or a poll in the meeting
- [ ] The judge joins the meeting and scores on their phone

Curriculum links

There is no national curriculum after 16, but the same skills run through A levels, T levels and further study: weighing evidence, building an argument and answering challenge. The Oracy Education Commission (2024) found strong support from business leaders and parents for more time on these skills in school.

> **GCSE English Language: the Spoken Language Endorsement.** A debate speech can be the formal presentation for the endorsement, which every exam board grades Pass, Merit or Distinction, separately from the GCSE. The topic must be agreed in advance, the speech prepared, and the student must answer questions and feedback, all in about ten minutes. Useful for students resitting GCSE English Language.
>
> An inter-school debate is excellent practice, but not the assessment itself: the boards need video of a sample of students, and these debates are never recorded. Run the assessed version in your own school, under your own recording policy, using the same motion.

> Oracy is growing in importance: the Curriculum and Assessment Review (November 2025) recommended a national oracy framework, and new primary and secondary frameworks are planned to go with the revised national curriculum from September 2028.

Further reading

- DfE: National curriculum in England, English programmes of study
  https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/national-curriculum-in-england-english-programmes-of-study
- DfE: Citizenship programmes of study, Key Stages 3 and 4
  https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/national-curriculum-in-england-citizenship-programmes-of-study
- DfE: Political impartiality in schools
  https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/political-impartiality-in-schools
- Awarding bodies: Spoken Language Endorsement for GCSE English Language (AQA)
  https://filestore.aqa.org.uk/resources/english/AQA-8700-SL-ENDORSEMENT.PDF
- English-Speaking Union: Schools' Mace handbook
  https://www.esu.org/competitions/schools-mace/
- Voice 21: The Oracy Framework
  https://voice21.org/
- Oak National Academy: Participating in effective debates (Key Stage 3)
  https://www.thenational.academy/teachers/programmes/english-secondary-ks3/units/participating-in-effective-debates/lessons

The running order is recommended, not compulsory: change the stages or timings to suit your students. The format is a draft and will be reviewed by debate educators before national use.